

Seeking, Finding, Reigning, and Resting

A Christian Theological Reading of Gospel of Thomas, Saying 2

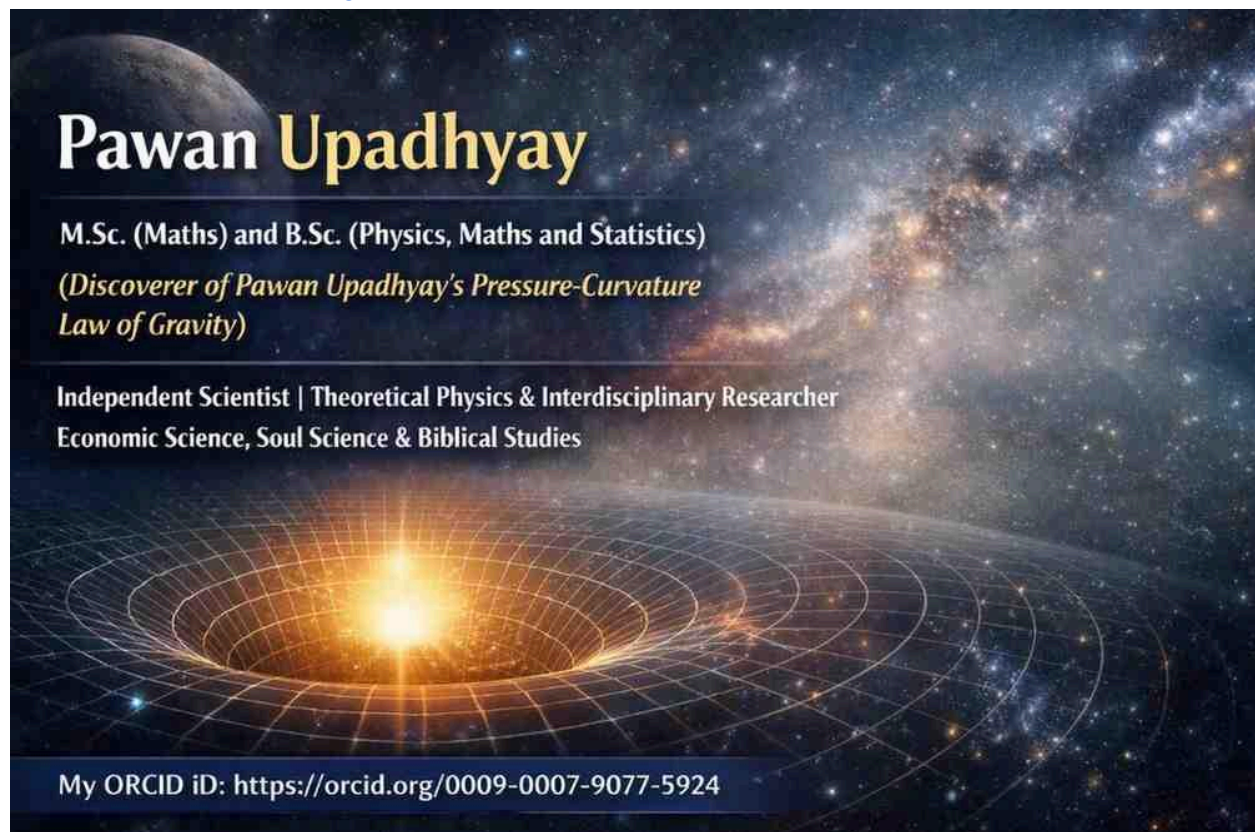
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Abstract

Gospel of Thomas Saying 2 describes a progression in the spiritual life: seeking, finding, trouble, astonishment, reign, and rest. This paper examines the saying word by word and develops a Christian theological interpretation centered on Jesus Christ as the Living Word and the Spirit of Truth. Particular attention is given to the enigmatic statement that the seeker “will

reign over the All.” The Coptic text preserved in Nag Hammadi Codex II concludes with this expression, while Greek fragments associated with the saying preserve a different ending involving reigning and resting.

The paper argues that, within a Christian interpretive framework, the seeker may be understood as one who persistently seeks divine Truth, encounters that Truth through Christ, experiences the disturbance and astonishment produced by revelation, and ultimately participates in spiritual authority. The paper further explores whether “reigning over the All” can be understood as the reign of Truth in the human heart and as participation in Christ's authority over the visible and invisible creation. This interpretation is then compared with Johannine teaching concerning the Spirit of Truth and the Living Word. The distinction between what Saying 2 explicitly states and what is inferred through comparison with the canonical Christian Scriptures is maintained throughout.

1. Introduction

The *Gospel of Thomas* begins by describing its contents as the “hidden sayings” spoken by the living Jesus. Saying 2 immediately introduces one of its central themes:

“The one who seeks should not cease seeking until he finds. And when he finds, he will be dismayed. And when he is dismayed, he will be astonished. And he will be king over the All.”

Another translation renders the final portion:

“When he finds, he will become troubled. When he becomes troubled, he will be astonished, and he will rule over the All.”

The saying is striking because the discovery of Truth does not immediately result in comfort. Instead, **finding produces disturbance, disturbance produces astonishment, and astonishment leads to reign.**

The present study asks whether this progression can be read through a specifically Christian theological framework:

Seeking → Finding → Trouble → Astonishment → Reign → Rest

The proposed interpretation understands Jesus as the Living Word and connects the seeker's encounter with Truth to the Johannine **Spirit of Truth**, while understanding the final reign as spiritual authority exercised through Christ rather than merely political domination.

2. “Jesus Said”

The saying begins:

“Jesus said...”

This is significant for a Christian reading because Jesus is not treated merely as a teacher of philosophical wisdom.

The Gospel of John presents Christ as the **Word**:

“The Word became flesh...” — John 1:14

Thus, within the theological framework of this study, Jesus can be described as the **Living Word**.

The seeker therefore seeks Truth through the One who embodies and reveals Truth.

John 14:6 provides the crucial Christian connection:

“I am the way, and the truth, and the life.”

This does not prove that the author of Thomas intended precisely this Johannine interpretation. Rather, it establishes a theological framework through which a Christian reader can interpret Thomas 2.

3. “He Who Seeks”

The first action is **seeking**.

The seeker is not passive. He is engaged in a continuing search.

Simon Gathercole observes that the seeking/finding motif is also found in the Jesus tradition of Matthew and Luke and elsewhere in Thomas. He notes that Thomas 2 particularly emphasizes human participation in the process of discovery.

The biblical parallel is:

“Seek, and you will find.” — Matthew 7:7

The seeker therefore begins with a desire to discover what is hidden.

Within our proposed interpretation:

The seeker seeks Truth.

4. “Until He Finds”

The phrase “**until he finds**” introduces perseverance.

Seeking does not end when the search becomes difficult.

The person must continue until discovery occurs.

This is important because Thomas Saying 1 immediately precedes Saying 2 and speaks about discovering the meaning of the sayings. Scholars have noted the thematic connection between “finding” in Saying 1 and “seeking/finding” in Saying 2.

The movement is therefore:

Search → Discovery

But discovery is not the end.

It is the beginning of something more difficult.

5. “When He Finds, He Will Be Troubled”

This is one of the most remarkable statements in Saying 2.

Why should finding Truth produce trouble?

The Coptic tradition contains a disturbing or dismaying stage between finding and astonishment. Translations vary between words such as **troubled**, **disturbed**, **dismayed**, and related expressions.

A theological interpretation is that genuine revelation challenges the seeker's previous understanding.

The person does not simply acquire another piece of information.

Instead, his previous worldview is confronted.

Thus:

Truth is found → the old understanding is disturbed.

This disturbance can be understood as the crisis of transformation.

6. “When He Is Troubled, He Will Be Astonished”

The next movement is:

Trouble → Astonishment

Gathercole notes that both the Greek and Coptic traditions preserve the idea of wonder or astonishment accompanying discovery, while the Coptic form also contains a disturbing element. He observes that Thomas reverses the familiar philosophical association in which wonder begins philosophical inquiry: here astonishment follows discovery.

The seeker therefore moves beyond intellectual curiosity.

He has encountered something greater than his previous understanding.

In the proposed Christian interpretation:

The Truth first troubles the person, then awakens him.

Astonishment represents the moment when the seeker begins to perceive the deeper reality revealed by Truth.

7. The Spirit of Truth

At this point, the interpretation can be connected to the Gospel of John.

John repeatedly uses the expression:

“Spirit of truth.”

It occurs in John 14:17, 15:26, and 16:13. John describes the Spirit as dwelling with believers, bearing witness concerning Jesus, and guiding them into truth.

John 16:13 is particularly important:

“When the Spirit of truth comes, he will guide you into all the truth...”

The Spirit therefore does not operate independently of Christ's teaching in John's presentation. The Spirit teaches, reminds the disciples of Jesus' words, testifies about Jesus, and guides them into truth.

This provides a theological basis for your interpretation:

Jesus Christ → Spirit of Truth → Holy Word → spiritual transformation

However, this connection should be described honestly as a **canonical-Christian theological interpretation of Thomas**, rather than as an explicit statement in Thomas Saying 2.

8. “He Will Reign Over the All”

This is the central interpretive problem.

The Coptic text reads in substance:

“He will reign over the All.”

The phrase has received different interpretations.

Simon Gathercole discusses the expression “the All” and concludes that in Thomas 2 it most likely refers broadly to **the universe/all things**, rather than one of the more specialized meanings proposed in some discussions of Nag Hammadi cosmology. He also notes that the Coptic expression gives the saying a cosmic dimension.

Petr Pokorný similarly interprets the Coptic “All” in terms of the visible and invisible world and connects the idea of participation in God's rule with biblical material.

Therefore, your interpretation that **“the All” can include the spiritual and created order** has an important point of contact with scholarly interpretation.

9. Reigning Through Jesus Christ

Your interpretation adds an explicitly Christological dimension:

The seeker reigns through Jesus Christ.

This means that the seeker does not become an independent divine ruler.

Rather, spiritual authority comes from Christ.

The Gospel of John provides an important conceptual parallel. The Spirit of Truth is sent in relation to Jesus and testifies concerning Him. The Spirit guides believers into Truth and communicates what belongs to Christ.

Therefore, within your theological model:

Jesus Christ is the source.

The Spirit of Truth communicates the Truth.

The seeker receives and lives the Truth.

The authority belongs ultimately to Christ.

10. Holy Words and Miracles

Your interpretation further proposes that the reign occurs through **holy words and holy miracles**.

The canonical Gospels present Jesus' words and works together. His miracles demonstrate authority over sickness, demons, nature, and death.

From this perspective, miracles are not merely displays of supernatural power. They function as signs of the authority of the One who speaks.

Therefore, your proposed interpretation of Thomas 2 can understand:

“He will reign over the All”

as authority manifested through the holy Word and its works.

However, this is an important methodological distinction:

Thomas 2 does not explicitly say “he will perform miracles.”

The connection with miracles comes from interpreting Thomas 2 through the canonical portrait of Jesus.

That distinction strengthens rather than weakens the research paper because it makes clear where the textual evidence ends and theological synthesis begins.

11. Reigning in the Heart

Your interpretation also emphasizes that this reign occurs **in the heart**.

This idea is particularly interesting when considered alongside Thomas Saying 3, which says that the kingdom is “inside of you, and outside of you.”

Thus, within a broader Thomas reading, spiritual reality is not necessarily restricted to an external kingdom.

The reign can begin within the person.

The Truth becomes the governing principle of the heart.

In Christian terms:

The Word enters the heart → the heart is transformed → Truth governs the person → the transformed person participates in Christ's authority.

This provides a theological explanation for your statement:

“He will reign in the heart.”

12. “After He Has Reigned, He Will Rest”

There is an important textual issue here.

The Coptic text preserved at Nag Hammadi ends Saying 2 with “**he will reign over the All.**” However, the Greek fragments associated with the saying appear to preserve a sequence involving **reigning and then resting**.

Thus, “rest” is not simply an unquestioned part of the surviving Coptic wording.

Nevertheless, the Greek evidence makes the sequence significant:

Reign → Rest

Some scholars have connected this rest with the fulfillment of the spiritual journey. Pokorný, for example, discusses “rest” as the counterpart to the activity of becoming king and connects it with the fulfillment of human life.

Therefore, your interpretation of the final rest as **spiritual peace in God** can be developed as a theological conclusion, although the precise textual history of the phrase must be acknowledged.

13. The Complete Interpretation

The proposed Christian interpretation can now be expressed as follows:

The seeker continues seeking Truth until he finds it. When he encounters Truth, his former understanding is disturbed. Through this disturbance he becomes astonished and spiritually awakened. Through Jesus Christ, the Living Word, and through the Spirit of Truth, he receives and follows the Holy Word. The authority of that Word is manifested through holy works. He therefore participates in Christ's authority and “reigns over the All,” with Truth reigning in his heart and extending toward the spiritual and created order. Having completed this work of spiritual reign, he enters into rest.

This interpretation goes beyond the bare wording of Thomas 2, but it creates a coherent Christian theological synthesis using Thomas, John, and the canonical portrait of Jesus.

14. Textual Interpretation vs. Theological Interpretation

For academic accuracy, the two should not be confused.

Saying 2	Your Christian interpretation
Seeks	Seeks divine Truth
Finds	Encounters Truth through Christ

Troubled	Old understanding is challenged
Astonished	Spiritual awakening
Reigns over the All	Participates in Christ's spiritual authority
Holy words	Word/Truth received through Christ
Miracles	Authority manifested through holy works
Reign in the heart	Truth governs the inner person
Rest	Final spiritual peace/rest

The left column concerns the **text**.

The right column represents the **theological synthesis being proposed in this study**.

That distinction is essential for a research paper.

15. Conclusion

Gospel of Thomas Saying 2 presents an unusual progression:

Seeking → Finding → Trouble → Astonishment → Reign → Rest

Its central mystery is the transition from **astonishment to reign**.

The Coptic phrase “reign over the All” gives the saying a cosmic dimension, and scholarly interpretations have understood “the All” in terms of the universe or visible and invisible creation.

A Christian theological reading can place this cosmic authority within the larger revelation of Jesus Christ as the Living Word and the work of the Spirit of Truth. John's Gospel describes the Spirit of Truth as one who remains with Christ's followers, bears witness to Jesus, teaches them, and guides them into truth.

Accordingly, the seeker's reign need not be understood as ordinary political domination. It can be understood as **participation in spiritual authority through Christ**, beginning with the transformation of the heart.

The seeker first seeks Truth.

He then finds Truth.

Truth troubles him because Truth transforms him.

Trouble becomes astonishment.

Astonishment becomes spiritual awakening.

Through Christ and the Spirit of Truth, the Holy Word becomes the source of his spiritual authority.

The Truth reigns in the heart.

And the journey ultimately moves toward rest.

The deepest significance of Saying 2, therefore, may lie not merely in **finding Truth**, but in what happens **after Truth has been found**: the seeker himself must be transformed until the Truth he sought becomes the Truth by which he lives.

Selected Sources

- *Gospel of Thomas*, Saying 2, Coptic and Greek witnesses.
- Simon Gathercole, *The Gospel of Thomas: Introduction and Commentary* — discussion of Thomas 1–2, the seeking/finding motif, astonishment, and “the All.”
- Petr Pokorný, *A Commentary on the Gospel of Thomas* — discussion of ruling over the All, rest, and the visible/invisible world.
- Gospel of John 14:17; 15:26; 16:13 — the Spirit of Truth.

2nd Research Paper

Research Note

Greek Sentence Study and Coptic Sentence Study of Gospel of Thomas, Saying 2

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1. Purpose of the Study

This note examines **Gospel of Thomas, Saying 2** in its two principal linguistic witnesses:

1. the **Greek text**, preserved in the Oxyrhynchus fragments; and
2. the **Coptic text**, preserved in Nag Hammadi Codex II.

The purpose is to study the sentence itself—its vocabulary, grammar, sequence, and meaning—before developing theological interpretation.

The saying is attributed directly to **Jesus**:

“Jesus said...”

Therefore, the object of this study is the saying attributed to Jesus, not a saying presented as spoken by Thomas.

Part I — Greek Sentence Study

2. Greek Text

The Greek text of Saying 2 is reconstructed from the Oxyrhynchus witness approximately as follows:

λέγει Ἰησοῦς· μὴ παυσάσθω ὁ ζητῶν τοῦ ζητεῖν ἕως ἂν εὕρῃ, καὶ ὅταν εὕρῃ
θαμβηθήσεται, καὶ θαμβηθεὶς βασιλεύσει, καὶ βασιλεύσας ἀναπαήσεται.

Transliteration

legei Iēsous; mē pausasthō ho zētōn tou zētein heōs an heurē, kai hotan heurē
thamvēthēsetai, kai thamvētheis basileusei, kai basileusas anapaēsetai.

3. Sentence Structure

The Greek sentence can be divided into five movements:

A. Seeking

μὴ παυσάσθω ὁ ζητῶν τοῦ ζητεῖν

“Let the one who seeks not cease seeking.”

The central verb is related to:

ζητέω — zēteō

meaning:

to seek, search for, look for, desire, inquire.

The saying therefore begins with continuous seeking.

B. Finding

ἕως ἄν εὑρῇ

“until he finds.”

The verb:

εὕρισκω — heuriskō

means:

to find, discover, obtain.

The grammatical structure indicates that the seeking continues **until discovery occurs**.

Thus:

ζητεῖν → εὑρῇ

seeking → finding

C. Astonishment

καὶ ὅταν εὑρῇ θαμβηθήσεται

“And when he finds, he will be astonished.”

The important verb is:

θαμβηθήσεται — thamvēthēsetai

from:

θαμβέω — thambeō

with meanings associated with:

astonishment, amazement, being overwhelmed or stunned.

The finding therefore produces a powerful reaction.

The sequence is:

Find → Astonishment

D. Reigning

The next phrase is:

καὶ θαμβηθεὶς βασιλεύσει

Literally:

“and having been astonished, he will reign.”

The verb:

βασιλεύσει — basileusei

comes from:

βασιλεύω — basileuō

meaning:

to reign, be king, exercise royal authority.

This is important.

The Greek does not merely say that the seeker becomes knowledgeable.

It uses a **royal verb**.

The grammatical sequence is:

θαμβηθεῖς → βασιλεύσει

having been astonished → he will reign

The astonishment is therefore immediately followed by reign.

E. Rest

The final Greek phrase is:

καὶ βασιλεύσας ἀναπαήσεται

Literally:

“and having reigned, he will rest.”

The verb:

ἀναπαήσεται — anapaēsetai

comes from:

ἀναπαύω — anapauō

meaning:

to rest, receive rest, cease from activity.

The final sequence is therefore:

βασιλεύσει → βασιλεύσας → ἀναπαήσεται

he will reign → having reigned → he will rest.

4. Complete Greek Progression

The Greek sentence can therefore be represented as:

Seeking

εὖρη

Finding

θαμβηθήσεται

Astonishment

βασιλεύσει

Reigning

ἀναπαήσεται

Rest

Seek → Find → Be Astonished → Reign → Rest

A commonly translated form is:

“Jesus said: Let him who seeks continue seeking until he finds. When he finds, he will become troubled. When he becomes troubled, he will be astonished, and he will reign over the All.”

6. Coptic Sentence Structure

The Coptic sentence follows this progression:

A. Seeking

The seeker is instructed to continue seeking.

The basic conceptual movement is:

Seeking → persistence

The person must not stop his search.

B. Finding

The search eventually reaches:

Finding

The seeker discovers what he has been seeking.

This is the turning point of the sentence.

C. Becoming Troubled

The Coptic version then introduces:

“he will become troubled.”

This is a major difference from the surviving Greek form.

The Coptic therefore gives:

Finding → Trouble

The discovery does not immediately produce comfort.

Instead, the discovery produces disturbance.

For a theological interpretation, this can be understood as the crisis that occurs when Truth confronts the seeker's previous understanding.

D. Becoming Astonished

The next stage is:

“when he becomes troubled, he will be astonished.”

Thus:

Trouble → Astonishment

This gives the Coptic version a four-stage transformation:

Seek → Find → Trouble → Astonishment

E. Reigning Over the All

The final major expression is:

“he will reign over the All.”

Unlike the Greek fragment, the Coptic text explicitly contains the expression translated:

“the All.”

This makes the scope of the reign particularly important for interpretation.

The Coptic version therefore concludes its preserved form with:

Astonishment → Reign over the All

7. Greek and Coptic Compared

The two witnesses can be placed side by side conceptually:

Greek	Coptic
Seeking	Seeking
Finding	Finding
Astonishment	Trouble
Reigning	Astonishment
Rest	Reigning over the All

The most significant differences are:

Greek

Finding → Astonishment → Reign → Rest

Coptic

Finding → Trouble → Astonishment → Reign over the All

Therefore, the two witnesses should not simply be treated as identical translations.

They preserve different aspects of the saying.

8. Theological Significance of the Difference

The Coptic addition of **trouble** makes the inner transformation more explicit.

The progression becomes:

Truth is found

↓

The seeker is troubled

↓

The seeker becomes astonished

↓

The seeker reigns

This can be interpreted as follows:

The discovery of Truth first challenges the person's former understanding. The resulting disturbance leads to astonishment or awakening. Having undergone this transformation, the person enters into a condition described as **reigning**.

The Greek form emphasizes a slightly different endpoint:

Finding → Astonishment → Reigning → Rest

The Greek therefore gives special prominence to the connection between **reigning and resting**.

9. “Reign” in the Two Witnesses

The Greek verb is:

βασιλεύω — basileuō

to reign / to be king / to exercise royal authority.

The Coptic uses a corresponding expression for ruling/reigning.

Therefore, the idea of **royal authority** is genuinely present in the saying.

However, the text itself does not explicitly say:

“He will rule politically.”

Nor does it explicitly state:

“Everyone will obey him.”

A theological interpretation may understand the reign as **spiritual authority**, but this must be distinguished from the literal lexical meaning of the verb.

10. “The All”

The Coptic ending is especially important:

“he will reign over the All.”

“The All” gives the statement a broad scope.

A Christian theological interpretation may understand this as extending beyond ordinary human society to the **created and spiritual order**.

This corresponds to the interpretation under investigation in this study:

The seeker reigns through Jesus Christ, and his authority extends over the spiritual and created order.

However, the exact identification of “the All” with **spirits and creatures** is an interpretation. The Coptic expression itself does not enumerate those categories.

11. Jesus, the Living Word, and the Spirit of Truth

The linguistic study itself does not establish the doctrine that Jesus is the Living Word or that the Spirit of Truth is in Jesus Christ.

Those ideas come from the wider Christian Scriptures.

John 1 identifies Jesus with the Word:

“The Word became flesh.”

John also speaks repeatedly of:

“the Spirit of truth.”

Jesus says that the Spirit of Truth will guide His followers into Truth and will glorify Him.

Therefore, when Saying 2 is interpreted within a Johannine Christian framework, the progression may be understood as:

Jesus Christ, the Living Word

↓

Spirit of Truth

↓

Holy Word / Truth

↓

Seeker receives Truth

↓

Transformation

↓

Reign through Christ

↓

Rest

This is a theological synthesis rather than a direct translation of the Coptic or Greek sentence.

12. Holy Words, Miracles, and Reign

The canonical Gospels portray Jesus' authority through both **His words and His works**.

Jesus' words and miracles demonstrate authority over sickness, demons, nature, and death.

Consequently, within the theological interpretation being developed here, the phrase:

“He will reign over the All”

can be understood as spiritual authority exercised **through Jesus Christ and the Holy Word**, with divine power manifested through holy works.

The interpretation can therefore be stated:

Through Jesus Christ and the Spirit of Truth, the seeker receives the Holy Word. Through the authority of that Word, manifested in holy works, he participates in Christ's reign over the All. The reign begins in the heart, where Truth becomes the governing reality.

Again, this is a theological interpretation and not a claim that Saying 2 explicitly contains the words **Spirit of Truth, miracle, heart, or Jesus Christ as the source of the seeker's reign.**

13. Final Comparative Diagram

Greek Witness

Jesus says

↓

Do not stop seeking

↓

Until you find

↓

You will be astonished

↓

You will reign

↓

Having reigned, you will rest

Coptic Witness

Jesus says

↓

Continue seeking

↓

Until you find

↓

You will be troubled

↓

You will be astonished

↓

You will reign over the All

14. Working Theological Interpretation

Taking the Greek and Coptic evidence together, while also bringing in the Christian understanding of Jesus and the Spirit of Truth, the proposed interpretation is:

Jesus, the Living Word, calls the seeker to continue seeking until he finds the Truth. When the seeker encounters Truth, he is troubled because Truth transforms his former understanding. Through the Spirit of Truth, he becomes astonished and spiritually awakened. Through Jesus Christ, he receives authority associated with the Holy Word. He therefore reigns over the All—not merely through worldly power, but through spiritual authority, with Truth reigning in the heart and extending toward the spiritual and created order. After the reign comes rest.

This formulation preserves an important scholarly distinction:

The Greek and Coptic texts tell us what the witnesses actually contain.

The Christian theological interpretation explains those words in relation to Jesus Christ, the Living Word, the Spirit of Truth, holy works, spiritual authority, and final rest.

That distinction allows the interpretation to be developed without confusing the ancient wording with later theological synthesis.

3rd Research Paper

Truth, Wisdom, and the Troubled Seeker

A Study of Gospel of Thomas, Saying 2

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Abstract

Gospel of Thomas Saying 2 presents a distinctive sequence in the teaching attributed to Jesus: seeking, finding, trouble, astonishment, and reign. The saying begins with the command to continue seeking until finding occurs. The Coptic version then describes the seeker as becoming troubled, followed by astonishment and finally reign over “the All.” The surviving Greek witness presents a related but somewhat different sequence: seeking, finding, astonishment, reign, and rest.

This paper examines the saying from the perspective that **Truth is associated with wisdom and knowledge**. It proposes that the seeker is not merely searching for information but pursuing wisdom and Truth. When Truth is discovered, the seeker becomes troubled because genuine knowledge transforms his previous understanding. The disturbance is followed by astonishment, which represents a deeper awakening. The paper then considers the statement that the seeker will “reign over the All” and explores its possible theological relationship to Jesus Christ, the Living Word, and the Spirit of Truth. The distinction between the wording of Saying 2 itself and this broader Christian theological interpretation is maintained throughout.

1. Introduction

The second saying of the *Gospel of Thomas* begins with a command to the seeker:

“Let him who seeks continue seeking until he finds.”

It then presents a surprising development:

“When he finds, he will become troubled. When he becomes troubled, he will be astonished, and he will rule over the All.”

The saying therefore does not portray the discovery of Truth as immediately comfortable.

Instead, finding produces **trouble**.

Trouble produces **astonishment**.

Astonishment leads to **reign**.

This sequence raises a fundamental question:

Why would finding Truth trouble the person who has been seeking it?

The present study proposes that this can be understood if Truth is considered in relation to **wisdom and knowledge**.

The seeker searches for wisdom.

He continues searching until he discovers it.

But when genuine wisdom is discovered, it challenges the understanding that existed before the discovery.

The result is trouble.

2. The Speaker: Jesus

The saying is introduced explicitly as a saying of Jesus:

“Jesus said...”

The Greek fragment likewise begins with λέγει Ἰησοῦς (“Jesus says/said”).

Therefore, this paper will refer to the speaker as **Jesus**, while recognizing that the historical question of how the sayings were transmitted and compiled is a separate scholarly question.

The prologue of Thomas describes the collection as sayings spoken by the **living Jesus** and written down by Didymos Judas Thomas.

Thus the central subject of Saying 2 is:

Jesus speaking to the seeker.

3. Truth, Wisdom, and Knowledge

The present interpretation begins with a conceptual relationship:

Truth → Wisdom → Knowledge

These three concepts are not identical in every philosophical or biblical context. Nevertheless, they can be closely related.

Truth is that which corresponds to reality.

Knowledge is the apprehension or recognition of what is true.

Wisdom is the ability to understand and live according to what is true.

Therefore, for this study:

The seeker searches for Truth through the pursuit of wisdom and knowledge.

This is an interpretive framework rather than a claim that the Greek verb for “seek” literally means “seek wisdom.”

Simon Gathercole describes the seeking/finding movement in Saying 2 as a process of “**sapiential research**” leading to discovery. He also connects it with the broader biblical and Jesus-tradition motif of seeking and finding.

This provides an important point of contact with the proposed interpretation.

4. “Let Him Who Seeks Continue Seeking”

The Greek fragment begins:

μὴ παυσάσθω ὁ ζητῶν τοῦ ζητεῖν

The central idea is:

“Let the one who seeks not cease seeking.”

The verb associated with seeking is **ζητέω (zēteō)**.

The seeker therefore possesses an active responsibility.

He must continue.

The command is not:

“Seek briefly.”

It is:

Do not stop seeking until you find.

This makes perseverance an essential part of the spiritual journey.

The seeker does not abandon the search because wisdom is difficult.

He continues until discovery.

5. “Until He Finds”

The Greek contains:

ἕως ἃν εὑρῇ

meaning approximately:

“until he finds.”

The verb comes from **εὕρισκω (heuriskō)**, “to find” or “discover.”

The structure therefore establishes two complementary actions:

ζητεῖν — seeking

and

εὑρῇ — finding.

The seeker is moving toward an objective.

The search has a destination.

This is important for the present interpretation:

The person seeks wisdom until wisdom is found.

The discovery is not merely accumulation of facts.

It is a transformation-producing discovery.

6. Finding Wisdom Produces Trouble

The Coptic version contains the important statement:

“When he finds, he will become troubled.”

This is the central feature of the present study.

If the seeker has been looking for wisdom, why should obtaining wisdom produce trouble?

The answer may be that **real knowledge can destroy false understanding.**

Before finding Truth, the seeker possesses a particular conception of reality.

After finding Truth, that conception must change.

The person therefore experiences a conflict:

Old understanding

versus

Newly discovered Truth

This produces disturbance.

The discovery is therefore not merely informative.

It is transformative.

7. Why Truth Can Trouble the Seeker

Consider the difference between ordinary information and transformative knowledge.

A person may learn a new fact without changing his life.

But if a person discovers something that overturns his fundamental understanding of reality, the consequences are much greater.

He may have to reconsider:

- what he believed;
- what he valued;
- what he considered important;
- what he considered true;
- and how he understands himself.

Therefore:

The greater the Truth discovered, the greater the potential disturbance to the previous understanding.

This provides a possible explanation for the sequence in Saying 2:

Finding → Trouble

Gathercole observes that the Coptic version does appear to introduce a disturbing element between finding and astonishment.

8. Trouble Is Not the Final State

The seeker does not remain troubled.

The Coptic saying continues:

“When he becomes troubled, he will be astonished.”

This creates another transformation:

Trouble → Astonishment

The trouble therefore becomes part of a process.

The person begins by seeking.

He finds.

Finding disrupts him.

The disruption leads to astonishment.

Astonishment can be understood as the moment when the seeker begins to perceive the significance of what has been discovered.

Thus:

Trouble is the doorway to deeper understanding.

9. Astonishment as Spiritual Awakening

The Greek text uses a verb associated with astonishment or amazement:

θαμβηθήσεται

The Greek sequence is:

finding → astonishment → reign.

The Coptic adds the stage of trouble:

finding → trouble → astonishment → reign.

The two witnesses therefore agree on the importance of **astonishment**, even though they differ in the stage immediately preceding it.

Gathercole notes that Thomas places astonishment **after finding**, reversing the more familiar philosophical association of wonder as the beginning of inquiry.

This is significant.

The seeker does not begin with the final astonishment.

He arrives there **after discovering something**.

10. From Knowledge to Transformation

At this point, the relationship between Truth, wisdom, and knowledge becomes clearer.

The seeker begins with:

desire for Truth

He then engages in:

seeking

He reaches:

knowledge/discovery

The discovery produces:

trouble

The trouble leads to:

astonishment

Therefore the process can be represented:

Seeking wisdom

↓

Finding Truth

↓

Receiving knowledge

↓

Being troubled

↓

Becoming astonished

↓

Being transformed

The knowledge is therefore not merely intellectual.

It changes the person who receives it.

11. Reigning Over the All

The Coptic version then says that the seeker:

“will rule over the All.”

This is the most difficult part of the saying.

The Greek version instead has:

“he will reign, and having reigned he will rest.”

Thus the Coptic emphasizes:

reign over the All

while the Greek emphasizes:

reign → rest.

The concept of reigning is nevertheless present in both.

The Greek uses the royal verb:

βασιλεύω — basileuō

meaning to reign or exercise royal authority.

The seeker therefore does not merely “understand” Truth.

The saying associates his transformed condition with **reigning**.

12. What Does “The All” Mean?

The Coptic expression translated “**the All**” is particularly important.

Scholarly discussion has considered whether the expression should be understood cosmically, metaphysically, or in another more specialized sense. A recent commentary summarized in available scholarship interprets the phrase in this context most naturally as **all things/the created world**, rather than requiring a technical reference to a divine realm.

Therefore, the statement can at minimum be understood as having a very broad scope:

The seeker will reign over the All.

Your proposed interpretation extends this to:

spiritual and created beings.

That is possible as a theological interpretation, but the Coptic phrase itself does not explicitly list “spirits and creatures.”

13. Jesus Christ as the Source of the Reign

The present study goes beyond the immediate wording of Thomas 2 by placing it within Christian theology.

The proposed interpretation is:

The seeker does not reign through his own independent power. He reigns through Jesus Christ.

This is important because the seeker is not being presented as becoming the ultimate source of Truth.

Rather:

Christ is the source; the seeker receives.

The seeker receives Truth.

The seeker is transformed by Truth.

The seeker then participates in authority associated with Truth.

Thus:

Christ → Truth → transformation → spiritual authority

14. Truth and the Spirit of Truth

The Gospel of John provides the theological framework for connecting Truth with the **Spirit of Truth**.

Jesus speaks of:

“the Spirit of truth.”

John 16:13 says that the Spirit of Truth will guide the disciples into Truth.

John 15:26 describes the Spirit as bearing witness about Jesus.

John 16:14 says that the Spirit will glorify Jesus.

Therefore, within a Christian theological interpretation:

Jesus Christ and the Spirit of Truth are intimately connected in the revelation of Truth.

This allows the Saying 2 journey to be interpreted as:

Seeking Truth

↓

Finding Truth

↓

Being transformed by Truth

↓

Receiving spiritual authority through Christ

It is important to emphasize that **Thomas Saying 2 itself does not use the expression “Spirit of Truth.”** This connection is made through comparison with Johannine Christianity.

15. The Holy Word

The Christian interpretation can be developed further through the concept of Jesus as the **Living Word**.

John 1 identifies Christ with the Word and describes the Word becoming flesh.

Therefore:

Jesus Christ = Living Word

Within this framework, the seeker is ultimately seeking not merely abstract information but Truth revealed through the Living Word.

The movement becomes:

Seeking wisdom

↓

Finding Truth

↓

Encountering the Living Word

↓

Transformation

This gives a Christ-centered interpretation to the seeking process.

16. Reigning in the Heart

Your interpretation also proposes that the reign occurs **in the heart**.

This is consistent with a broader Thomasian interest in an inward dimension of the kingdom. Saying 3, immediately following Saying 2, says that the kingdom is “**within you and outside you.**”

Therefore, Saying 2 and Saying 3 can be read together for interpretive purposes:

Saying 2: the seeker reigns over the All.

Saying 3: the kingdom is within and outside.

This does not prove that Saying 2 means “reign in the heart,” but it provides a contextual reason to investigate an inward dimension.

Under your interpretation:

Truth first reigns in the heart.

The transformed heart becomes governed by Truth rather than falsehood.

17. Holy Words and Miracles

The proposed Christian interpretation also connects the reign with the **holy words and works of Jesus**.

The canonical Gospels present Jesus exercising authority through His teaching and mighty works.

Therefore, within this theological framework, the seeker's authority is understood as derived from Christ rather than generated independently by the seeker.

The interpretation can be stated:

Through Jesus Christ and the Spirit of Truth, the seeker receives the Holy Word. Through the authority of that Word, and through works that manifest divine authority, he participates in Christ's reign.

This is an interpretive synthesis.

Thomas Saying 2 does **not explicitly say “miracles.”**

Therefore, a research paper must distinguish:

Textual claim:

The seeker will reign over the All.

Theological interpretation:

The seeker participates in Christ's authority through the Holy Word and its works.

18. Greek and Coptic Perspectives

The Greek and Coptic witnesses are essential to the interpretation.

Greek

The surviving Greek text gives:

Seeking → Finding → Astonishment → Reign → Rest

Coptic

The Coptic text gives:

Seeking → Finding → Trouble → Astonishment → Reign over the All

The Coptic version therefore supports your observation particularly strongly:

“When he finds, he gets troubled.”

The Greek witness, however, preserves the important final concept:

“having reigned, he will rest.”

The difference should remain visible rather than being erased through a single harmonized translation.

19. The Complete Interpretive Model

Your interpretation can now be expressed as a complete theological model:

Truth is wisdom and knowledge.

A person begins as a seeker.

He seeks wisdom.

He does not stop.

He continues seeking until he finds.

He discovers Truth.

But the discovery is not comfortable.

When he finds, he becomes troubled.

The Truth challenges his former understanding.

His trouble leads to astonishment.

When he becomes troubled, he is astonished.

Through Jesus Christ, the Living Word, and through the Spirit of Truth, he receives a deeper understanding of divine Truth.

He is transformed.

Then comes:

“He will reign over the All.”

The reign is understood as authority received through Christ rather than independent worldly domination.

Truth begins to reign in the heart and, in the broader interpretation, the seeker participates in Christ's authority over the created and spiritual order.

The Greek witness then adds:

“Having reigned, he will rest.”

Thus the entire journey can be represented:

SEEK

Seek wisdom and Truth



FIND

Discover Truth



TROUBLE

The Truth challenges the former understanding



ASTONISHMENT

The seeker awakens to the significance of Truth



REIGN

Through Christ, Truth exercises spiritual authority



REST

The journey reaches its final rest

20. Conclusion

Gospel of Thomas Saying 2 presents the seeker with a journey that begins in uncertainty and ends in authority and rest.

The central insight of this study is that **finding does not immediately produce comfort.**

The seeker seeks wisdom.

He finds.

But finding Truth troubles him.

Why?

Because Truth does not merely add knowledge to the old person. It challenges and transforms the person who receives it.

The trouble therefore becomes part of the path to astonishment.

Astonishment then precedes reign.

The Coptic witness makes this sequence especially clear:

Finding → Trouble → Astonishment → Reign over the All.

The Greek witness adds another dimension:

Reign → Rest.

Within the Christian theological interpretation developed here, the Truth being sought is ultimately understood in relation to Jesus Christ, the Living Word, and the Spirit of Truth.

The seeker therefore does not become the independent source of Truth.

Rather:

He seeks Truth, receives Truth, is transformed by Truth, and participates in the authority of Truth through Jesus Christ.

The journey begins with **seeking wisdom.**

It passes through the painful discovery of Truth.

It reaches **astonishment and spiritual awakening.**

It proceeds to **reign.**

And finally, in the Greek witness, it reaches **rest.**

Thus Saying 2 can be understood as a description not merely of gaining knowledge, but of the **transformation of the seeker by the Truth he discovers.**

Primary and Scholarly Sources

- *Gospel of Thomas*, Saying 2, Greek Oxyrhynchus fragment and Coptic Nag Hammadi witness.
 - Simon Gathercole, *The Gospel of Thomas: Introduction and Commentary*, discussion of Saying 2, including seeking/finding, astonishment, and the Coptic disturbance.
 - Bentley Layton, *The Gospel According to Thomas: Introduction, Translation and Commentary*, discussion of Saying 2 and “the All.”
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4th Research Paper

The Seeker, Truth, and the Spirit of Truth

A Theological Study of Gospel of Thomas Saying 2

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Abstract

Gospel of Thomas Saying 2 presents a sequence attributed to Jesus in which a seeker continues seeking until he finds, becomes troubled, becomes astonished, and ultimately reigns over “the All.” The surviving Greek and Coptic witnesses are important because they preserve related but not identical forms of the saying. The Greek witness contains the sequence seeking, finding, astonishment, reigning, and resting, while the Coptic witness includes the additional stage of becoming troubled and concludes with the statement that the seeker will reign over “the All.”

This paper develops a Christian theological interpretation of the saying in which **Truth is understood in relation to wisdom and knowledge**, and in which the **Spirit of Truth enlightens the human spirit**. Knowledge leads to wisdom, wisdom leads the seeker toward Truth, and the discovery of Truth produces an inner disturbance because Truth transforms the seeker's previous understanding. The paper further interprets the final reign through Jesus Christ, understood within Johannine Christianity as the Living Word, and considers the possibility that this reign begins within the heart before extending to the wider spiritual and created order.

The paper distinguishes between the **textual claims of Gospel of Thomas Saying 2** and the **theological synthesis proposed here**, particularly concerning the Trinity, the Spirit of Truth, miracles, and the reign of Truth in the heart.

1. Introduction

The second saying of the *Gospel of Thomas* begins with a command to the seeker and ends with an extraordinary promise.

The Coptic witness may be translated:

“Jesus said, ‘Let him who seeks continue seeking until he finds. When he finds, he will become troubled. When he becomes troubled, he will be astonished, and he will reign over the All.’”

The surviving Greek witness gives a closely related sequence:

“Jesus says: Let the one who seeks not cease seeking until he finds, and when he finds he will be astonished, and having been astonished he will reign, and having reigned he will rest.”

The saying therefore presents a progression:

Coptic

Seeking → Finding → Trouble → Astonishment → Reign over the All

Greek

Seeking → Finding → Astonishment → Reign → Rest

The central research question of this paper is:

What kind of transformation is described by the movement from seeking to finding, from finding to trouble and astonishment, and from astonishment to reign?

A Christian theological answer may be developed by considering Truth, wisdom, knowledge, Jesus Christ, the Spirit of Truth, and spiritual authority.

2. Jesus as the Speaker

The saying explicitly identifies its speaker as **Jesus**.

The Greek opening is:

λέγει Ἰησοῦς

legei Iēsous

Literally:

“Jesus says.”

The Coptic tradition likewise introduces the saying as a saying of Jesus.

This distinction is important.

The work is called the *Gospel of Thomas*, but Saying 2 is presented as **Jesus speaking**.

Thomas is associated with the transmission or attribution of the collection, whereas the speaker identified within the saying is Jesus.

Accordingly, this study refers to the teaching as **Jesus' saying**.

3. The Greek Text

The Greek witness of Saying 2 is reconstructed approximately as:

**λέγει Ἰησοῦς· μὴ παυσάσθω ὁ ζητῶν τοῦ ζητεῖν ἕως ἂν εὕρῃ, καὶ ὅταν εὕρῃ
θαμβηθήσεται, καὶ θαμβηθεὶς βασιλεύσει, καὶ βασιλεύσας ἀναπαήσεται.**

The important vocabulary includes:

Greek	Transliteration	Meaning
ζητῶν	zētōn	seeking
ζητεῖν	zētein	to seek
εὑρη	heurē	he finds
θαμβηθήσεται	thamvēthēsetai	he will be astonished
θαμβηθείς	thamvētheis	having been astonished
βασιλεύσει	basileusei	he will reign
βασιλεύσας	basileusas	having reigned
ἀναπαήσεται	anapaēsetai	he will rest

The Greek sentence is constructed around a chain of actions.

Seeking → Finding → Astonishment → Reigning → Rest

The repeated verbal forms create a sense of progression.

4. The Coptic Witness

The complete *Gospel of Thomas* is preserved in Coptic in Nag Hammadi Codex II.

The Coptic witness differs from the Greek witness at an important point.

The Coptic version includes the idea:

“When he finds, he will become troubled.”

It then continues:

“When he becomes troubled, he will be astonished.”

Thus:

Finding → Trouble → Astonishment

The Greek fragment does not preserve this exact sequence. Instead it moves from finding directly to astonishment.

This difference is essential to interpretation.

The Coptic witness makes the psychological or spiritual crisis of discovery especially prominent.

5. Seeking

The first major action is **seeking**.

The Greek uses vocabulary derived from:

ζητέω — zēteō

meaning to seek, search, inquire, or look for.

The command is essentially:

Do not cease seeking.

The seeker therefore possesses perseverance.

The search is not temporary.

The saying directs the seeker to continue:

until he finds.

Within the theological framework of this study, the object of seeking is understood as **wisdom and Truth**.

The seeker is not simply looking for information.

He is looking for understanding that can transform his existence.

6. Truth, Knowledge, and Wisdom

The proposed theological model begins with three related concepts:

Truth → Knowledge → Wisdom

They should not be treated as exact synonyms.

Truth concerns what is real and true.

Knowledge is the apprehension of what is true.

Wisdom involves understanding and living according to truth.

The model proposed here reverses the order in terms of the seeker's experience:

The person receives knowledge → knowledge develops into wisdom → through wisdom the person finds Truth.

The Spirit of Truth provides the illumination through which the person can understand.

Thus:

Spirit of Truth

↓

Enlightenment

↓

Knowledge

↓

Wisdom



Truth

This is a theological model, not a claim that the Greek word **ζητέω** literally means “seek wisdom.”

7. The Spirit of Truth

The concept of the **Spirit of Truth** is especially prominent in the Gospel of John.

Jesus says:

“the Spirit of truth” — John 14:17

Jesus further says:

“When the Spirit of truth comes, he will guide you into all the truth.” — John 16:13

The Spirit therefore has an epistemological function: the Spirit guides the believer into Truth.

John also presents the Spirit as bearing witness to Jesus:

“He will bear witness about me.” — John 15:26

And:

“He will glorify me.” — John 16:14

These passages provide an important theological framework for interpreting the seeker.

The seeker does not discover Truth merely through independent intellectual effort.

The Spirit of Truth enlightens the human spirit.

8. One Most High God and the Spirit of Truth

The theological position developed in this study understands:

God the Father, God the Son, Jesus Christ, and God the Holy Spirit as the One Most High God.

Consequently, the phrase **Spirit of Truth** is understood as referring to the one divine reality rather than to three separate spirits.

This theological formulation emphasizes divine unity:

One Most High God → One Spirit of Truth

At the same time, the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit may be distinguished in their relational and revelatory roles.

The Father is God.

The Son is God.

The Holy Spirit is God.

Yet God is one.

This doctrine belongs to Christian theology rather than to the explicit vocabulary of Thomas Saying 2. Therefore, it should be understood as the theological framework through which the saying is being interpreted.

9. The Holy Spirit Enlightens the Human Spirit

The next stage in the proposed theological model is illumination.

The Holy Spirit enlightens the human spirit.

Through this enlightenment, the person receives knowledge.

Therefore:

Holy Spirit → human spirit → knowledge

Knowledge is the beginning of conscious understanding.

But knowledge alone does not necessarily constitute wisdom.

Wisdom requires deeper understanding.

Thus:

Knowledge → Wisdom

The seeker therefore progresses beyond the possession of information.

He begins to understand what the knowledge means.

10. Wisdom and the Discovery of Truth

The seeker continues searching until he finds.

Within this study, the finding is understood as the discovery of **Truth**.

Therefore:

The seeker seeks wisdom until he finds Truth.

This can be represented:

Seeker

↓

Seeking

↓

Knowledge

↓

Wisdom

↓

Truth

This interpretation gives special importance to the phrase:

“until he finds.”

The search has a destination.

The seeker is not condemned to endless searching.

He eventually encounters what he has been seeking.

11. Finding Truth Produces Trouble

The Coptic version then gives the remarkable statement:

“When he finds, he will become troubled.”

The discovery of Truth therefore creates a crisis.

Why?

Because Truth challenges the seeker's previous understanding.

The person may have constructed his worldview around incomplete or false assumptions.

When Truth is discovered, those assumptions can no longer remain unchanged.

Thus:

Finding Truth → disturbance of previous understanding

The trouble is therefore interpreted here as a **transformative crisis**.

The person must pass from his former understanding into a new understanding.

12. The Purpose of the Trouble

The trouble is not presented as the final state.

The saying immediately continues:

“When he becomes troubled, he will be astonished.”

Therefore:

Trouble → Astonishment

The trouble has a purpose within the progression.

The seeker first discovers Truth.

The discovery challenges him.

The challenge produces disturbance.

The disturbance leads to astonishment.

Astonishment represents a deeper realization.

The person begins to see what he previously could not see.

13. Astonishment

The Greek verb:

θαμβηθήσεται

is associated with astonishment, amazement, or being overwhelmed.

The Greek sentence then says:

θαμβηθείς βασιλεύσει

“having been astonished, he will reign.”

This grammatical connection is significant.

Astonishment directly precedes reigning.

The progression is:

Finding → Astonishment → Reigning

The Coptic version makes the process longer:

Finding → Trouble → Astonishment → Reigning

The two witnesses therefore converge on the importance of astonishment immediately before reign.

14. Reigning

The Greek verb is:

βασιλεύσει — basileusei

from:

βασιλεύω — basileuō

meaning:

to reign, to be king, to exercise royal authority.

This is not simply the vocabulary of learning.

The transformed seeker is described using the language of **royal authority**.

The Coptic version further specifies:

“He will reign over the All.”

The expression therefore expands the scope of the reign.

15. Reigning Through Jesus Christ

The proposed Christian interpretation understands the seeker's authority as **received through Jesus Christ**.

The seeker does not become the independent source of divine authority.

Rather:

Jesus Christ is the source.

The seeker receives Truth.

Truth transforms him.

Through Christ, he participates in spiritual authority.

Therefore:

Jesus Christ → Truth → transformation → spiritual authority

This interpretation is strengthened by the Christian understanding of Christ as the **Living Word**.

John 1 presents the Word as becoming flesh.

Thus, in this theological framework:

Jesus Christ is the Living Word.

The seeker who finds Truth is therefore ultimately encountering the Truth revealed through the Living Word.

16. The Holy Word

If Jesus Christ is understood as the Living Word, then the Holy Word is not merely a collection of written statements.

The Word is associated with the living revelation of God in Christ.

The Spirit of Truth guides the seeker toward Truth.

The Word reveals Truth.

Therefore:

Spirit of Truth → Word → Truth

The seeker receives knowledge and wisdom through divine illumination and ultimately encounters Truth through Christ.

17. Holy Words and Holy Works

The canonical Gospels portray Jesus exercising authority through both His teaching and His mighty works.

He teaches with authority.

He heals.

He commands unclean spirits.

He exercises authority over nature.

He raises the dead.

Within the theological model developed here, these works can be understood as manifestations of the authority of the Holy Word.

Therefore, the phrase:

“He will reign over the All”

may be interpreted as participation in spiritual authority derived from Christ.

The seeker does not possess independent divine power.

His authority is **through Jesus Christ**.

18. Reigning in the Heart

The reign can also be interpreted inwardly.

Before considering authority over the wider creation, Truth must become authoritative **within the person**.

The Holy Word becomes the governing reality of the heart.

Thus:

Truth reigns in the heart.

The person is increasingly governed by Truth rather than ignorance and falsehood.

This inward dimension is compatible with the broader kingdom language found elsewhere in Thomas, particularly Saying 3, which speaks of the kingdom in relation to what is within and outside the person.

Nevertheless, “reign in the heart” is an interpretive conclusion; Saying 2 itself does not contain those exact words.

19. Reigning Over the All

The Coptic text gives:

“He will reign over the All.”

The phrase **“the All”** gives the reign a broad scope.

A theological interpretation may understand the All as encompassing the created and spiritual order.

Thus the proposed interpretation is:

The person, transformed through Truth and united to Christ, participates in Christ's authority over the All.

This can include the spiritual realm and the created order within the theological model.

But again, the Coptic text itself does not explicitly list “spirits and creatures.”

The statement must therefore remain identified as an interpretation.

20. The Greek Ending: Reign and Rest

The Greek witness adds an important element:

καὶ βασιλεύσας ἀναπαύσεται

“And having reigned, he will rest.”

The final Greek verb is related to:

ἀναπαύω — anapauō

meaning:

to rest.

Thus the Greek progression concludes:

Reign → Rest

This creates a complete movement from seeking to final rest.

21. Greek and Coptic Together

The two witnesses can therefore be read together:

Greek

Seek → Find → Astonishment → Reign → Rest

Coptic

Seek → Find → Trouble → Astonishment → Reign over the All

Rather than choosing one witness and ignoring the other, the differences should be studied.

The Coptic emphasizes:

the trouble of finding.

The Greek emphasizes:

the rest following reign.

Together they produce a fuller interpretive picture:

Seek → Find → Trouble → Astonishment → Reign → Rest

22. Complete Theological Model

The theological model proposed by this study can now be stated:

The One Most High God is the Spirit of Truth. God the Father, God the Son Jesus Christ, and God the Holy Spirit are one God. The Holy Spirit enlightens the human spirit, through which the person receives knowledge. Through knowledge the person gains wisdom,

and through wisdom he seeks and finds Truth. When he finds Truth, he becomes troubled because Truth challenges and transforms his former understanding. Through this trouble he becomes astonished and spiritually awakened. Through Jesus Christ, the Living Word, he receives spiritual authority. He reigns over the All, with Truth first reigning in his heart and, within this interpretation, his authority extending toward the spiritual and created order. Having completed his reign, he enters into rest.

This is the central theological interpretation proposed in this paper.

23. Interpretive Sequence

The entire model can be represented as follows:

DIVINE SOURCE

One Most High God — Spirit of Truth

↓

ILLUMINATION

Holy Spirit enlightens the human spirit

↓

KNOWLEDGE

The person receives knowledge

↓

WISDOM

Knowledge develops into wisdom

↓

TRUTH

Through wisdom the seeker finds Truth

↓

TROUBLE

Truth challenges the former understanding



ASTONISHMENT

The seeker becomes spiritually awakened



CHRIST

Jesus Christ, the Living Word



HOLY WORD

Truth is received and lived



REIGN

The seeker participates in Christ's spiritual authority



HEART

Truth reigns within



THE ALL

Authority extends toward the spiritual and created order



REST

The journey reaches its final rest

24. Textual Claims and Theological Claims

For scholarly clarity, it is necessary to distinguish the two.

Explicitly present in Saying 2

- Jesus is presented as the speaker.
- The seeker is commanded to continue seeking.
- The seeker eventually finds.
- The Coptic witness says he becomes troubled.
- He becomes astonished.
- He reigns over the All in the Coptic witness.
- The Greek witness says that he reigns and subsequently rests.

Theological interpretation developed in this paper

- Truth is the ultimate object of seeking.
- Truth is closely related to wisdom and knowledge.
- The Spirit of Truth enlightens the human spirit.
- Jesus Christ is the Living Word.
- The seeker receives authority through Jesus Christ.
- Holy words and holy works participate in the manifestation of divine authority.
- The reign begins in the heart.
- The reign encompasses the spiritual and created order.
- Final rest represents spiritual rest in God.

The second group should therefore be presented as **interpretation**, not as a literal translation of Thomas Saying 2.

25. Conclusion

Gospel of Thomas Saying 2 describes a journey beginning with **seeking** and moving toward **finding, trouble, astonishment, reign, and rest**.

Its central mystery is why finding produces trouble.

The proposed answer is that Truth is not merely information.

Truth transforms.

The seeker searches for wisdom.

Through knowledge and wisdom, he finds Truth.

When Truth is found, the seeker's former understanding is disturbed.

The disturbance produces astonishment.

Astonishment leads to reign.

Within the Christian theological framework developed here, the seeker does not reign through independent human power.

He reigns **through Jesus Christ, the Living Word**, in connection with the **Spirit of Truth**.

The Holy Spirit enlightens the human spirit.

The person receives knowledge.

Knowledge develops into wisdom.

Through wisdom, the person finds Truth.

Truth then transforms the seeker.

The transformed person participates in Christ's authority.

The reign begins in the heart, where Truth becomes the governing reality, and the Coptic expression “over the All” permits consideration of a wider cosmic and spiritual scope.

Finally, the Greek witness supplies the profound conclusion:

“Having reigned, he will rest.”

Thus the saying can be interpreted as a journey:

Seeking → Knowledge → Wisdom → Truth → Trouble → Astonishment → Reign through Christ → Rest

The seeker does not merely **find Truth**.

He is **changed by the Truth he finds**.

Selected References

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 3. Bentley Layton, *The Gospel According to Thomas: Introduction, Translation and Commentary*.
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 6. Gospel of John 14:16–17 — the Spirit of Truth.
 7. Gospel of John 15:26 — the Spirit's witness concerning Jesus.
 8. Gospel of John 16:13–14 — the Spirit of Truth, guidance into Truth, and glorification of Christ.
 9. Matthew 7:7 — seeking and finding.
 10. 1 Corinthians 2 — divine revelation and spiritual understanding.
-

Thesis and Method

Central Thesis

This study argues that **Gospel of Thomas Saying 2 presents the seeker's discovery as a transformative process rather than as the simple acquisition of information**. The saying describes a progression in which persistent seeking leads to finding, and finding produces a profound transformation in the seeker.

The Coptic witness presents the progression approximately as:

Seeking → Finding → Trouble → Astonishment → Reigning over the All

The Greek witness preserves a closely related but somewhat shorter progression:

Seeking → Finding → Astonishment → Reigning → Rest

The difference between the two witnesses is significant and will be examined rather than prematurely harmonized.

Within a **Christian theological framework**, this study proposes that the object of the seeker's search may be understood in relation to **Truth, knowledge, and wisdom**. The text itself does not explicitly state that the seeker is searching for "Truth" or "wisdom"; therefore, this identification belongs to the level of theological interpretation rather than literal translation.

The proposed Christian interpretation is that **divine illumination produces knowledge, knowledge develops into wisdom, and wisdom enables the seeker to recognize Truth.** When the seeker encounters Truth, the discovery is not necessarily comfortable. It challenges the seeker's previous understanding and therefore produces "trouble." This troubled state develops into astonishment, representing a deeper recognition of what has been discovered.

The subsequent statement concerning reigning is understood spiritually. **"He will reign over the All"** is not interpreted primarily as political domination. Rather, within this Christian framework, it may signify participation in spiritual authority through Truth and through Jesus Christ. This reign begins with the reign of Truth within the human heart and may be understood as extending toward the spiritual and created order.

The Greek conclusion, **"having reigned, he will rest,"** gives the progression a final movement toward rest. In this theological interpretation, rest can be understood as the completion of the seeker's transformation and the peace that follows union with divine Truth. The identification of this rest specifically with heavenly rest, however, remains a theological interpretation rather than an explicit statement of the text.

The central thesis can therefore be stated in one sentence:

Saying 2 depicts a progression in which the persistent seeker encounters Truth, is transformed by the troubling and astonishing character of that discovery, and ultimately participates in spiritual reign through Jesus Christ before entering into rest.

Research Questions

This study addresses five principal questions.

1. What does the Greek text actually say?

The Greek witness will be examined lexically and grammatically, with particular attention to the verbs describing:

- seeking;
- finding;
- becoming astonished;
- reigning;
- resting.

The study will consider the grammatical forms of these verbs and the way their sequence creates the movement of the saying.

The principal progression is:

Seeking → Finding → Astonishment → Reign → Rest

2. What does the Coptic text actually say?

The Coptic witness will be examined independently from the Greek, particularly with regard to the expressions corresponding to:

- seeking;
- finding;
- becoming troubled;
- becoming astonished;
- reigning;
- “the All.”

The Coptic witness is especially important because it preserves the additional stage of **trouble** before astonishment and explicitly includes the expression concerning “**the All.**”

Its progression may therefore be represented as:

Seeking → Finding → Trouble → Astonishment → Reign over the All

The Coptic evidence will be presented in its original script, with transliteration and grammatical explanation, so that the argument does not depend exclusively upon an English translation.

3. What is the significance of the difference between the Greek and Coptic witnesses?

The Greek and Coptic witnesses will not be treated as though they were identical.

The Greek witness gives approximately:

Seeking → Finding → Astonishment → Reign → Rest

The Coptic witness gives approximately:

Seeking → Finding → Trouble → Astonishment → Reign over the All

The study will first examine each witness on its own terms.

Only after this independent examination will the witnesses be brought into dialogue with one another.

This approach is important because the additional Coptic reference to **trouble**, the explicit phrase “**over the All**,” and the Greek conclusion concerning **rest** each contribute something significant to the interpretation.

The study therefore follows the principle:

First establish the witnesses; then interpret their relationship.

4. Can the seeker’s search be interpreted as a search for Truth, wisdom, and knowledge?

The study will carefully distinguish between the **lexical meaning of the ancient words** and the broader theological interpretation proposed here.

The Greek verbs for “seek” and “find” do not themselves mean “seek wisdom” or “find Truth.” Therefore, the identification of the object of seeking with Truth, wisdom, or knowledge cannot simply be inserted into the translation.

Instead, this interpretation must be developed through:

1. the literary context of Saying 2;
2. the surrounding sayings of the *Gospel of Thomas*;
3. relevant ancient concepts of revelation and wisdom;
4. comparison with selected Christian texts;
5. and theological synthesis.

Thus, the argument will not claim:

“The Greek word for seeking literally means seeking Truth.”

Rather, it will ask:

“Can the seeker’s act of seeking and finding reasonably be understood, within a Christian theological framework, as a search for and discovery of divine Truth?”

5. Can Saying 2 be interpreted through the Christian concepts of the Living Word and the Spirit of Truth?

The study will examine whether the movement of Saying 2 can be illuminated through selected canonical Christian passages concerning:

- Jesus Christ as the Word;
- the Spirit of Truth;
- divine revelation;
- spiritual understanding;
- seeking and finding;
- wisdom;
- and transformation.

Particular attention will be given to:

- **John 1:1–14** — Christ as the Word;
- **John 14:16–17** — the Spirit of Truth;
- **John 15:26** — the Spirit's testimony concerning Christ;
- **John 16:13–14** — the Spirit guiding into Truth and glorifying Christ;
- **Matthew 7:7** — seeking and finding;
- **1 Corinthians 2** — spiritual revelation and understanding.

The purpose of these comparisons is **interpretive illumination**, not to claim that Saying 2 explicitly contains Johannine terminology or that the author of the *Gospel of Thomas* necessarily intended these particular canonical passages.

Method

This study employs a **four-stage method**:

1. Textual-critical analysis;
2. Lexical and grammatical analysis;
3. Literary and intertextual analysis;
4. Theological synthesis.

These stages are deliberately arranged so that theological interpretation follows, rather than replaces, examination of the textual evidence.

Stage One: Textual-Critical Analysis

The first stage establishes the textual evidence.

The Greek and Coptic witnesses will initially be examined separately. The study will identify:

- the original-language wording;
- significant textual differences;
- verbal forms;
- grammatical constructions;
- relevant semantic ranges;
- and differences between the Greek and Coptic witnesses.

Particular attention will be given to the fact that the witnesses do not preserve precisely the same sequence.

No theological conclusion should be treated as established before this textual analysis has been completed.

The controlling principle is:

First establish the text; then interpret the text.

This principle protects the study from allowing a preferred theological interpretation to determine what the ancient witnesses are assumed to say.

Stage Two: Lexical and Grammatical Analysis

The second stage examines the principal words according to their linguistic function rather than beginning with an English theological interpretation.

For the Greek text, particular attention will be given to:

ζητέω — seek

εύρίσκω — find

θαμβέω — astonish / be astonished

βασιλεύω — reign

ἀναπαύω — rest

The study will examine not only dictionary meanings but also the specific grammatical forms in Saying 2 and their function within the sequence of the saying.

The Coptic expressions will likewise be examined directly in Coptic script, accompanied by transliteration and grammatical explanation.

This approach is important because a theological argument should not be built merely upon the associations of an English translation.

The method therefore moves from:

Original Text → Grammar → Lexical Meaning → Context → Interpretation

rather than:

English Translation → Assumed Meaning → Theology

Stage Three: Literary and Intertextual Analysis

The third stage examines Saying 2 within the literary structure of the *Gospel of Thomas*.

Particular attention will be given to the relationship between Saying 2 and the immediately surrounding sayings, especially **Sayings 1–3**.

The study will investigate the significance of concepts such as:

- finding;
- the kingdom;
- the All;
- reigning;
- and rest.

The saying will then be compared with selected canonical Christian passages.

These comparisons will focus especially on the relationship between:

Seeking → Revelation → Truth → Transformation

and the Christian concepts of:

Spirit of Truth → Divine Revelation → Christ the Word → Spiritual Understanding

The intertextual analysis will therefore ask whether canonical Christian theology provides a coherent framework through which Saying 2 can be interpreted.

The study will not claim that such parallels prove direct literary dependence. Instead, they will be used to explore theological correspondence and interpretive possibilities.

Stage Four: Theological Synthesis

Only after the textual, linguistic, and literary stages have been completed will the study introduce its proposed theological synthesis.

The theological model is:

One Most High God

↓

Spirit of Truth

↓

Divine Illumination

↓

Knowledge

↓

Wisdom

↓

Truth

↓

Finding

↓

Trouble

↓

Astonishment

↓

Jesus Christ, the Living Word

↓

Spiritual Authority

↓

Reign over the All

↓

Rest

This sequence represents the theological interpretation proposed by this study. **It is not presented as a literal translation or as a statement that every stage is explicitly named in Saying 2.**

Rather, the model seeks to explain how the individual elements of the saying may be brought together within a Christian theology of revelation.

In this framework, the **Spirit of Truth** enlightens the human spirit. Through divine illumination, the person receives knowledge. Knowledge develops into wisdom, and wisdom enables the seeker to recognize Truth.

The encounter with Truth transforms the seeker.

Truth is therefore not merely information possessed by the mind. It becomes a reality that changes the person.

Theological Understanding of the Spirit of Truth

Within the theological framework proposed in this study, **the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit are not understood as three separate gods, but as the one Most High God.**

The phrase “**Spirit of Truth**” is used here as a theological expression for divine Truth and divine revelation, with particular attention to the Johannine presentation of the Spirit of Truth.

In this framework, Jesus Christ is the **Living Word**, while the Holy Spirit enlightens the human spirit and leads the seeker toward Truth.

The theological movement may therefore be expressed as:

God → Spirit of Truth → Illumination → Knowledge → Wisdom → Truth → Christ

This formulation belongs to the theological synthesis of the study and should not be presented as though Saying 2 itself explicitly formulates a Trinitarian doctrine.

The Controlling Distinction: Text, Interpretation, and Theology

A central methodological principle of this study is the distinction between three levels of argument.

Level 1 — Text

What do the Greek and Coptic witnesses actually say?

At this level, the study deals with words, grammar, textual witnesses, variants, and translation.

Level 2 — Interpretation

What meaning can reasonably be drawn from those words in their literary context?

At this level, the study examines the sequence of the saying and asks what the progression from seeking to finding, trouble, astonishment, reign, and rest signifies.

Level 3 — Theology

How can the saying be understood within a Christian theology of God, Christ, the Spirit of Truth, revelation, wisdom, spiritual authority, and rest?

At this level, the study develops its Christian theological interpretation.

These three levels must not be collapsed into one another.

For example:

Text

“He will reign over the All.”

Interpretation

The saying attributes an extraordinary form of authority to the transformed seeker.

Theological Synthesis

Within the proposed Christian framework, the transformed seeker participates in spiritual authority through **Truth revealed by the Spirit of Truth and through Jesus Christ, the Living Word**.

The theological conclusion is therefore built upon the text but is not identical to the text.

This distinction allows the study to advance a strong theological interpretation while remaining transparent about what Saying 2 explicitly states.

Working Hypothesis

The working hypothesis of this study is:

The “finding” of Saying 2 represents transformative discovery rather than merely the acquisition of information. In the Coptic witness, the subsequent state of “trouble” suggests that the discovery disrupts the seeker’s previous understanding, while the movement into astonishment signifies a deeper awakening to what has been encountered. This transformation is followed by the language of reign. Within a Christian theological framework, the process may be understood as the Spirit of Truth illuminating the human spirit, leading the seeker through knowledge and wisdom toward Truth revealed in Jesus Christ, the Living Word. The resulting spiritual authority is expressed through the language of reigning, while the Greek witness brings the progression to rest.

This hypothesis will be tested against the actual Greek and Coptic evidence rather than simply assumed at the beginning of the study.

Significance of the Study

The significance of this approach lies in bringing together three dimensions that are often examined separately:

Philology

What do the Greek and Coptic words actually mean, and how do their grammatical forms function?

Literary Interpretation

How does Saying 2 function within the literary context of the *Gospel of Thomas*?

Christian Theology

How might the saying be understood in relation to Christ, the Spirit of Truth, revelation, wisdom, spiritual authority, and rest?

The study therefore does not begin by imposing its theological conclusion upon the text.

Instead, its methodological movement is:

Text → Language → Context → Interpretation → Theology

This progression provides a disciplined framework for investigating the proposed relationship between:

Truth → Knowledge → Wisdom → Spirit of Truth → Jesus Christ → Spiritual Reign → Rest

Final Methodological Principle

The central discipline of this study can be summarized in one sentence:

The text must establish the possibilities of interpretation, interpretation must establish the theological questions, and theology must remain transparent about where it goes beyond the explicit wording of the text.

Accordingly, this study will treat Saying 2 first as an ancient textual witness, then as a literary and linguistic statement, and finally as a text capable of theological interpretation within the Christian faith.

The ultimate question is therefore not merely:

“What does Saying 2 say?”

but also:

“What transformation does Jesus describe through these words, and how might that transformation be understood in the light of Truth, wisdom, the Spirit of Truth, and Jesus Christ, the Living Word?”

Note on the Parabolic Words of Jesus

Jesus frequently communicated profound spiritual truths through **parables, images, symbolic language, and wisdom sayings**. Such sayings should not always be understood merely at the

level of their immediate or literal wording. A parable can use ordinary images and actions to communicate a deeper spiritual reality.

Therefore, when studying the sayings attributed to Jesus, the researcher should consider both the **surface meaning** and the **deeper meaning** communicated through the saying.

A parable may contain several levels of meaning. The words themselves form the first level, while the relationships between the images, actions, and progression of the saying may reveal a deeper theological message.

This principle is particularly important for **Gospel of Thomas Saying 2**. Jesus says:

“Let him who seeks continue seeking until he finds.”

The saying then moves through a remarkable sequence:

Seeking → Finding → Trouble → Astonishment → Reigning → Rest

These words can be read as more than a simple instruction to search for information. They can be understood as describing a **spiritual transformation of the seeker**.

The seeker begins by searching. Finding does not immediately produce comfort; instead, the discovery produces trouble and astonishment. The transformed person then reaches the language of reigning, and the Greek witness concludes with rest.

The deeper meaning may therefore concern the transformation that takes place when a person encounters divine Truth.

In a Christian theological interpretation, the saying can be read through the relationship between:

Spirit → Illumination → Knowledge → Wisdom → Truth → Transformation

The Holy Spirit enlightens the human spirit. Through this illumination, the person receives knowledge; through knowledge, wisdom develops; and through wisdom, the person comes to recognize Truth. The discovery of Truth can disturb the person's former understanding because Truth requires transformation rather than merely intellectual agreement.

The words of Jesus should therefore be approached with both **careful textual analysis and spiritual attentiveness**.

This does not mean that every possible symbolic meaning should automatically be attributed to Jesus. The deeper meaning must be tested against the wording of the text, its literary context, its historical setting, and the broader Christian Scriptures.

The methodological principle is therefore:

Jesus' parabolic and wisdom sayings should be examined not only for what they say on the surface, but also for the deeper spiritual reality they may communicate.

For this reason, Saying 2 should be studied as a **compressed wisdom saying describing a journey of seeking, discovery, transformation, spiritual authority, and rest.**

The purpose of this approach is not to replace the literal text with an imagined meaning. Rather, it is to allow the text's symbolic movement to be examined carefully so that its deeper theological significance can be considered.

The words are few, but the meaning may be deep.

Divine Illumination and the Human Person

Within the theological framework proposed in this study, the **Holy Trinity is understood as one divine illumination**. The Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit are the one Most High God, and divine illumination proceeds from the one divine source.

This divine illumination reaches the human person through the **Spirit**.

The movement may be expressed as:

One Most High God

↓

Father, Son, and Holy Spirit

↓

One Divine Illumination

↓

Human Spirit

↓

Mind, Brain, and Heart

↓

Knowledge and Wisdom

↓

Recognition of Truth

Divine illumination first illuminates the **spirit of the person**. The illuminated spirit then brings illumination to the person's **mind, brain, and heart**.

The **mind** receives understanding.

The **brain** is the physical instrument through which the person thinks, remembers, reasons, and processes what has been received.

The **heart** represents the person's inner center—the place of intention, desire, faith, understanding, and response.

Thus, divine illumination is not understood merely as the transmission of information to the intellect. It is a transformation of the whole person.

The movement can therefore be described as:

Divine illumination → illuminated spirit → enlightened mind → awakened heart → understanding → wisdom → recognition of Truth.

Within this framework, the **Spirit of Truth** is central to the process of illumination. The Spirit enlightens the human spirit, and the illuminated person becomes capable of perceiving Truth more deeply.

Jesus Christ, understood as the **Living Word**, is likewise central to this revelation. The illuminated seeker does not merely acquire abstract knowledge; the seeker comes to recognize Truth in relation to Christ.

This provides a theological framework for understanding the movement of Saying 2:

Seeking → Finding → Trouble → Astonishment → Reigning → Rest

The seeker searches because the person has not yet fully recognized what is being sought. Divine illumination enables the seeker to progress from ignorance toward knowledge, from knowledge toward wisdom, and from wisdom toward recognition of Truth.

When Truth is encountered, the person's previous understanding may be disturbed. This corresponds to the **trouble** described in the Coptic witness. The resulting **astonishment** can be understood as the awakening of the person to a reality greater than the person's previous understanding.

The transformation therefore occurs inwardly before it is expressed outwardly:

Truth must first reign within the person before the person can speak of spiritual reign.

In this interpretation, the phrase “**reign over the All**” is consequently connected with an inward transformation. The person who has been illuminated by Truth is no longer governed merely by former ignorance and understanding. The authority associated with “reigning” is therefore understood spiritually and theologically rather than primarily as political power.

The complete theological movement may be represented as:

One Most High God



Divine Illumination



Spirit of the Person Illuminated



Mind Illuminated



Heart Awakened



Knowledge



Wisdom



Truth Recognized



Truth Reigns Within



Spiritual Authority Through Christ



Reign



Rest

This model presents divine illumination as the beginning of the seeker's transformation. The seeker does not discover Truth by intellectual effort alone. Rather, the human search becomes fruitful when the person is illuminated by God.

Thus, **seeking and divine illumination belong together**: the person seeks, God illuminates, the spirit perceives, the mind understands, the heart receives, wisdom develops, and Truth is recognized.

The ultimate purpose of divine illumination is not merely that a person should know about Truth, but that Truth should illuminate and transform the whole person.

5th Research Paper

Divine Illumination and the Transformation of the Human Person

A Christian Theological Study

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Abstract

This study proposes a Christian theological model of **divine illumination** in which the one Most High God illuminates the human person through the divine Spirit. Within this framework, the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit are understood as the one God and as united in the one divine reality of Truth and illumination. Divine illumination first reaches the **spirit of the human person**, and the illuminated spirit brings understanding to the person's mind and awakens the heart.

The study proposes the following movement:

One Most High God → Divine Illumination → Human Spirit → Mind, Brain, and Heart → Knowledge → Wisdom → Truth

This model understands revelation not merely as the transfer of information but as a transformation of the whole person. The Spirit of Truth illuminates the human spirit, enabling the person to receive understanding, develop wisdom, recognize Truth, and respond to Truth inwardly.

The study then considers how this theological model can illuminate the progression found in Gospel of Thomas Saying 2:

Seeking → Finding → Trouble → Astonishment → Reigning → Rest

The argument does not claim that Saying 2 explicitly teaches the complete theological model. Rather, it proposes that, within a Christian theological framework, divine illumination provides a way of understanding how the seeker moves from seeking toward transformative recognition of Truth.

1. Introduction

The human search for Truth is one of the central questions of religious and philosophical thought.

A person may possess information without possessing wisdom. A person may possess knowledge without understanding its deeper significance. A person may understand an idea intellectually without allowing that understanding to transform the inner life.

Christian theology presents divine revelation differently. Revelation is not merely the communication of information from God to humanity. It is also an illumination through which the human person comes to perceive, understand, and respond to divine Truth.

This study develops the concept of **divine illumination** as a theological model for understanding that process.

The central proposal is:

Divine illumination illuminates the spirit of the person; the illuminated spirit brings light to the mind and awakens the heart, leading the person from knowledge toward wisdom and from wisdom toward recognition of Truth.

This model is then related to the Christian understanding of the **Spirit of Truth** and to Jesus Christ as the **Living Word**.

In the Gospel of John, Jesus speaks of the “Spirit of truth,” and the Spirit is described as dwelling with and being in the disciples. John further states that the Spirit of Truth will guide believers into Truth and testify concerning Christ.

These Johannine themes provide an important canonical framework for the theological model developed in this study.

2. The One Most High God and Divine Illumination

Within the theological framework proposed here, there is **one Most High God**.

The Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit are not understood as three separate gods. They are understood within the Christian doctrine of the Trinity as the one God.

For the purposes of this study, this unity is expressed through the concept of **one divine illumination**.

The formulation is:

One Most High God

↓

Father, Son, and Holy Spirit

↓

One Divine Illumination

The phrase “one divine illumination” is a theological formulation used by this study to describe the unity of God's revelation and illuminating activity.

It does not mean that the classical doctrine of the Trinity simply identifies the three persons as one person. Rather, the present study emphasizes the unity of the divine source from which revelation and illumination come.

Thus:

One God → One divine source of Truth → Divine illumination of the human person.

3. The Spirit of Truth

The concept of the **Spirit of Truth** is particularly important for this theological model.

In John's Gospel, Jesus promises another Advocate and identifies this Advocate with the “Spirit of truth.” The Spirit is described as being with the disciples and being in them.

John also describes the Spirit's relationship to Christ:

the Spirit of Truth “will testify about me.”

The Spirit therefore has a revelatory function.

John 16:13 presents the Spirit of Truth as guiding the disciples into Truth, while the following verse connects the Spirit's work with glorifying Christ.

Within the framework of this study, this provides a theological basis for understanding illumination as a movement toward Truth rather than merely an accumulation of information.

The Spirit illuminates.

The person perceives.

The mind understands.

The heart responds.

The person is transformed.

4. Divine Illumination and the Human Spirit

The first recipient of divine illumination, in the model proposed here, is the **human spirit**.

The movement is:

Divine Illumination → Human Spirit

The human spirit is understood as the inner dimension of the person through which divine revelation is received and perceived.

This does not mean that the physical brain is excluded from the process. Rather, the model distinguishes between the spiritual source of illumination and the human faculties through which the person experiences and processes that illumination.

The illuminated spirit therefore becomes the starting point of an integrated transformation.

The process may be represented as:

God

↓

Divine Illumination

↓

Human Spirit

↓

Mind and Understanding

↓

Heart and Response



Whole Person

5. Spirit, Mind, Brain, and Heart

The human person is not merely a thinking mechanism.

The human person possesses intellectual, physical, emotional, moral, and spiritual dimensions.

For this reason, the theological model distinguishes three related aspects of human response:

The Spirit

The spirit receives divine illumination.

The Mind and Brain

The mind understands, reasons, remembers, interprets, and organizes what has been perceived.

The brain is the physical organ through which human cognition occurs.

The Heart

The heart represents the person's inner center of desire, intention, faith, commitment, and response.

Thus, the movement of divine illumination is not intended to describe a medical or neurological mechanism. It is a **theological model of whole-person transformation**.

The model can therefore be expressed:

Spirit illuminated



Mind enlightened



Heart awakened



Person transformed

6. Illumination Is More Than Information

One of the most important distinctions in this study is the difference between **information** and **illumination**.

Information can be received without transformation.

A person may learn facts without becoming wise.

A person may know words without understanding their significance.

A person may understand an argument without allowing Truth to change the direction of life.

Divine illumination, by contrast, is understood here as an encounter with Truth that transforms the person.

Therefore:

Divine illumination is not merely the reception of information; it is the transformation of the person through divine Truth.

This distinction becomes particularly important when interpreting the movement from knowledge to wisdom.

7. From Knowledge to Wisdom

The proposed theological sequence is:

Illumination → Knowledge → Wisdom → Truth

Knowledge concerns what the person comes to understand.

Wisdom concerns how that knowledge is understood, integrated, and lived.

The distinction can therefore be expressed:

Knowledge asks: “What has been revealed?”

Wisdom asks: “What does this revelation mean, and how should it transform me?”

Within this framework, wisdom is not simply a larger quantity of knowledge.

Wisdom is knowledge understood in relation to Truth.

Therefore:

Divine illumination produces knowledge, knowledge develops into wisdom, and wisdom prepares the person to recognize Truth.

This is a theological model rather than a claim that Saying 2 itself explicitly gives this entire sequence.

8. Recognition of Truth

The goal of illumination is ultimately **recognition of Truth**.

The seeker does not merely possess information about Truth.

The seeker recognizes Truth.

This distinction is important.

To know *about* Truth and to recognize Truth are not necessarily the same thing.

The proposed process is:

Seeking

↓

Illumination

↓

Knowledge

↓

Wisdom



Recognition



Truth

The seeker therefore moves from external searching toward internal recognition.

The Truth that is recognized is understood, within this Christian framework, in relation to God and ultimately to Jesus Christ.

9. Jesus Christ as the Living Word

The Christian theological model developed here places **Jesus Christ** at the center of divine revelation.

The Johannine tradition identifies Christ with the Word and presents the Spirit of Truth as testifying concerning Christ. John 15:26 explicitly connects the Spirit's testimony with Jesus.

Thus the theological movement may be represented as:

God



Divine Illumination



Spirit of Truth



Truth



Jesus Christ, the Living Word

The term “**Living Word**” is used here as a theological description of Christ grounded especially in the Christian understanding of the Word in John 1.

The illuminated seeker therefore does not merely arrive at an abstract philosophical principle called Truth.

Within this Christian interpretation, Truth is encountered in relation to **Jesus Christ**.

10. The Inner Transformation of the Seeker

This theological model provides a framework for understanding spiritual transformation.

The seeker begins with a desire to know.

Divine illumination opens the inner person.

The spirit receives illumination.

The mind begins to understand.

The heart begins to respond.

Knowledge develops into wisdom.

Wisdom enables recognition of Truth.

Truth transforms the person.

Thus:

The purpose of illumination is not merely to make the person more informed, but to make the person more transformed by Truth.

11. Divine Illumination and Gospel of Thomas Saying 2

This model can be brought into dialogue with **Gospel of Thomas Saying 2**.

The saying presents a progression in which the seeker continues seeking until finding, after which the seeker experiences further transformation.

The Coptic witness presents:

Seeking → Finding → Trouble → Astonishment → Reigning over the All

The Greek witness presents a closely related progression:

Seeking → Finding → Astonishment → Reigning → Rest

The two witnesses differ, and those differences must be preserved in textual analysis.

Nevertheless, the sequence provides an important theological pattern.

The seeker does not simply seek and immediately become finished.

Finding becomes the beginning of transformation.

This is compatible with the theological model of divine illumination.

12. Finding and Illumination

Within the proposed interpretation, the seeker's "finding" may be understood as the recognition of Truth made possible through divine illumination.

The movement becomes:

Seeking

↓

Divine Illumination

↓

Finding

↓

Recognition of Truth

This interpretation does not claim that the Greek or Coptic word for "finding" literally means "finding Truth."

Rather, it proposes that the theological object of the seeker's search can be interpreted as Truth when the saying is read within a Christian framework.

13. Trouble as the Disruption of Former Understanding

The Coptic witness contains a stage of **trouble** between finding and astonishment.

Within this theological interpretation, trouble can signify the disruption caused when Truth challenges the seeker's previous understanding.

The sequence is therefore:

Finding → Trouble → Astonishment

The seeker has found something, but the discovery does not simply confirm everything the seeker previously believed.

Truth can expose error.

Truth can challenge assumptions.

Truth can overturn inadequate understanding.

Consequently, the encounter with Truth may initially be disturbing.

The trouble is therefore interpreted as part of transformation rather than as evidence that the seeker has failed.

14. Astonishment as Spiritual Awakening

After trouble comes astonishment.

Astonishment represents a deeper stage of recognition.

The seeker is no longer merely processing information.

The seeker is encountering something that exceeds previous understanding.

The movement is:

Knowledge → Understanding → Astonishment → Recognition

Within the theological framework proposed here, astonishment may therefore represent the awakening of the illuminated person to the depth of divine Truth.

15. Truth Must Reign Within

The transformation must first take place inwardly.

Therefore:

Truth must first reign within the person before the person can speak of spiritual reign.

This principle is central to the interpretation proposed in this study.

The language of “reigning” should not immediately be interpreted as political domination.

Rather, the first realm of divine reign is the human interior.

The movement is:

Spirit illuminated

↓

Mind enlightened

↓

Heart awakened

↓

Truth recognized

↓

Truth reigns within

Only after this inward transformation can the language of spiritual authority be considered.

16. Reigning Through Christ

Within the Christian theological framework, spiritual authority is understood in relation to **Jesus Christ**.

The seeker does not become spiritually authoritative through personal power alone.

Rather, spiritual authority is understood as participation in Truth revealed through Christ.

The theological movement is therefore:

Truth

↓

Christ

↓

Transformation

↓

Spiritual Authority

↓

Reign

This interpretation connects the language of Saying 2 with the broader Christian understanding of Christ and the Spirit of Truth.

The Spirit of Truth testifies concerning Christ and guides believers into Truth.

17. “Reign over the All”

The phrase “**reign over the All**” is one of the most striking elements of Saying 2.

Within this study, it is interpreted spiritually rather than primarily politically.

The phrase may be understood as describing the extraordinary authority associated with the transformed seeker.

Within the proposed theological model, that authority derives from Truth and is exercised through Christ.

The movement is therefore:

Illumination

↓

Truth

↓

Truth within the person

↓

Spiritual authority

↓

Reign over the All

This does not mean that the saying explicitly explains the mechanism of such reign.

Rather, it is the theological interpretation developed by this study.

18. Rest as the Completion of Transformation

The Greek witness concludes with the statement that, after reigning, the seeker will **rest**.

This gives the Greek sequence a final movement:

Seeking → Finding → Astonishment → Reigning → Rest

Within the theological framework proposed here, rest can represent the completion of the seeker's transformation.

The person has sought.

The person has found.

The person has been transformed.

Truth has become inwardly established.

Spiritual authority has followed.

The journey reaches rest.

In Christian theological interpretation, this rest may be associated with peace in God and the completion of the spiritual journey.

However, the specific identification of this rest with **heaven** is a theological interpretation and should not be presented as though Saying 2 explicitly says “heaven.”

19. The Complete Model of Divine Illumination

The theological model developed in this study can now be presented as a complete sequence:

One Most High God

↓

Father, Son, and Holy Spirit

↓

One Divine Illumination

↓

Spirit of Truth

↓

Human Spirit Illuminated

↓

Mind Enlightened

↓

Heart Awakened



Knowledge



Wisdom



Recognition of Truth



Jesus Christ, the Living Word



Truth Reigns Within



Spiritual Authority Through Christ



Reign



Rest

This sequence is a theological synthesis.

It should therefore be distinguished from the literal sequence of Gospel of Thomas Saying 2.

20. Relationship Between Divine Illumination and Saying 2

The relationship can be summarized in two levels.

Textual Level

Saying 2 presents the seeker as moving through:

Seeking → Finding → Trouble → Astonishment → Reign → Rest

with important differences between the Coptic and Greek witnesses.

Theological Level

This study proposes:

Divine Illumination → Spirit → Knowledge → Wisdom → Truth → Christ → Transformation → Spiritual Authority → Reign → Rest

The theological model therefore seeks to explain the deeper spiritual significance of the textual progression.

21. Text, Interpretation, and Theology

The study must maintain a clear distinction between three levels.

Text

What does the ancient witness actually say?

Interpretation

What meaning can reasonably be drawn from the saying?

Theology

How can that meaning be understood within Christian faith?

For example:

Text:

“He will reign over the All.”

Interpretation:

The transformed seeker receives or exercises extraordinary authority.

Theological synthesis:

The seeker participates in spiritual authority through Truth revealed by the Spirit of Truth and through Jesus Christ.

The third statement is therefore not presented as a literal translation of the first.

This distinction is essential for scholarly integrity.

22. The Human Person as a Temple of Illumination

Within this theological framework, the human person becomes the place in which divine illumination is received and expressed.

The process begins inwardly:

God illuminates the spirit.

The illuminated spirit influences understanding.

Understanding reaches the mind.

Truth awakens the heart.

The transformed heart shapes the person's life.

Thus divine illumination becomes visible through the whole person.

The person is not merely someone who **knows Truth**.

The person becomes someone whose **life is illuminated by Truth**.

23. Knowledge, Wisdom, and Truth

The relationship between these three concepts can be summarized as follows:

Knowledge

Knowledge is what the person comes to understand.

Wisdom

Wisdom is the deeper understanding and proper integration of knowledge.

Truth

Truth is the reality recognized through divine illumination and wisdom.

Therefore:

Knowledge without wisdom may remain incomplete; wisdom without Truth may remain uncertain; divine illumination leads the seeker toward recognition of Truth.

Within the Christian framework of this study, this Truth is ultimately understood in relation to God and revealed through Jesus Christ.

24. Theological Implications

Several theological implications follow from this model.

First, divine revelation is understood as **transformative**.

Second, the human person participates in revelation through an illuminated spirit.

Third, intellectual understanding and spiritual transformation are connected but not identical.

Fourth, the heart must participate in the reception of Truth; intellectual knowledge alone is insufficient.

Fifth, Christ is central to the Christian understanding of Truth.

Sixth, the Spirit of Truth is understood as the divine agent of guidance and illumination.

Seventh, spiritual authority follows transformation rather than preceding it.

Finally, the ultimate movement of the transformed person is toward rest.

25. Conclusion

This study has proposed a theological model in which **divine illumination transforms the human person from within**.

The model begins with the one Most High God and proceeds through divine illumination to the human spirit:

God → Divine Illumination → Human Spirit → Mind → Heart → Knowledge → Wisdom → Truth

Within Christian theology, this illumination is understood in relation to the **Spirit of Truth** and **Jesus Christ, the Living Word**. John's Gospel provides especially important theological language for this framework, describing the Spirit of Truth as dwelling with believers, testifying concerning Christ, and guiding them into Truth.

When this model is brought into dialogue with Gospel of Thomas Saying 2, the seeker's journey can be interpreted as a process of spiritual transformation:

Seeking → Finding → Trouble → Astonishment → Reigning → Rest

The seeker does not merely acquire information.

The seeker is illuminated.

The spirit is awakened.

The mind receives understanding.

The heart responds.

Knowledge develops into wisdom.

Wisdom leads toward recognition of Truth.

Truth transforms the person.

Truth begins to reign within.

And, within the Christian theological interpretation proposed here, spiritual authority is exercised through Christ.

The final movement toward rest represents the completion of the journey.

The central theological proposition can therefore be stated:

Divine illumination begins in the human spirit, transforms the mind and heart, leads knowledge toward wisdom and wisdom toward Truth, and through Jesus Christ transforms the seeker into a person in whom Truth reigns.

In this understanding, divine illumination is not simply the giving of light to the intellect.

It is the illumination and transformation of the whole human person by divine Truth.